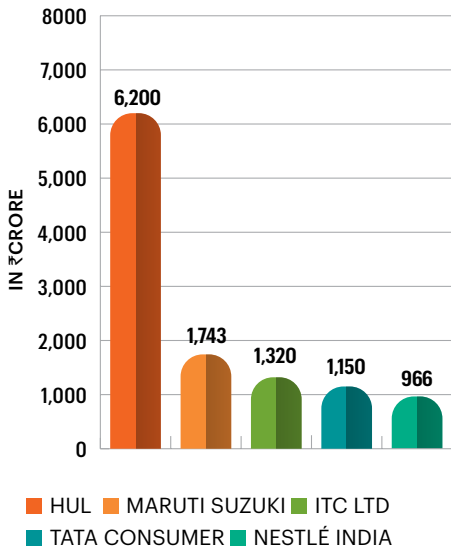


BIG SPENDERS

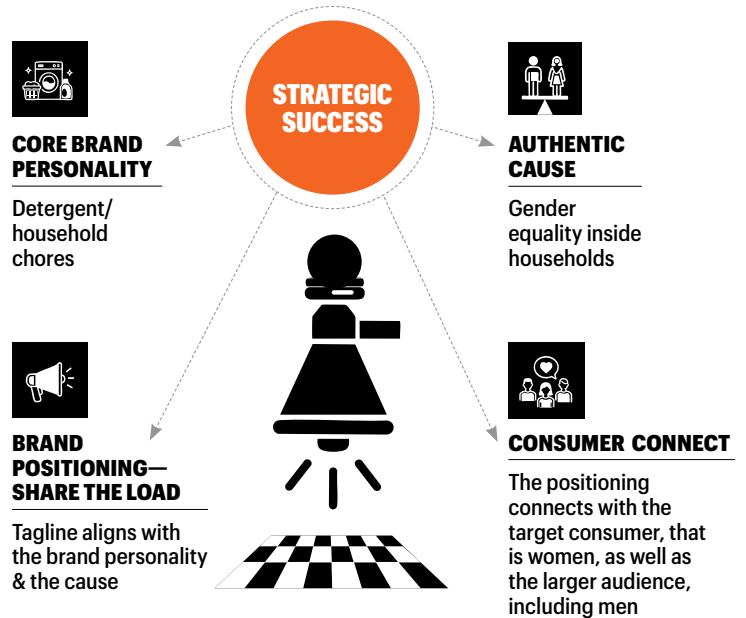
• Marketing & advertising spending of top consumer companies in FY25



SOURCE ANNUAL REPORTS

ARIEL'S EXEMPLARY "SHARE THE LOAD" CAMPAIGN

• Decoding the structure of Ariel's successful campaign



that depicted an inter-faith marriage.

These instances were supposed to be examples of companies supporting fair social causes, or what many see as brand activism.

"Brand activism is a high stakes marketing strategy where a brand chooses to take a public stand on a contemporary issue in an attempt to project itself as a responsible corporate citizen, and also garner customers' good will," says Goyal of Rediffusion.

But in all the above cases, the brands in question received brickbats instead of the bouquets they may have expected.

MINDING THEIR BUSINESS

"Brands are in the business of business and they should stick to minding their business," says Saurabh Uboweja, strategist and managing partner at BOD Group, a New Delhi-based strategy and consulting firm. "Activism or wokeism are not part of a marketing communication or branding strategy syllabus."

To be sure, brands operate in the larger macrocosm of society that includes cultural practices, religious

beliefs, and also political ideologies of its people, who also happen to be consumers.

Since brands themselves are considered to be live entities, insulating them from the larger fabric of society may not be entirely possible, and there may be a temptation on the part of brand custodians to join the conversations their consumers are caught up in.

"Triggering emotions to make a connection with customers has long been the route brands of all kinds have taken since long," says Francis of Brand Finance India.

LEARNING LESSONS

Identifying the right issue and devising a fool-proof communication plan around it has always been a challenge.

"It has become even more challenging now in today's hyper-sensitive, highly polarised social-media dominated environment," says Goyal. "Today, one small slip can flare up into a full-blown controversy in no time, throwing consumers, employees and investors, all into a tizzy."